

Zigging and zooming all over the place: Young children's meaning making and movement in the museum

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Abstract

This article draws attention to the walking and running of young children as a key element of their multimodal communicative practices. In addition, the article argues that the walking and running of young children can be seen as a place-making activity, acknowledging the power of young children to create meaning in their world. Drawing on ethnographic data from ongoing research with young children and their families in museums, I present some examples of ways in which young children move during museum visits as a powerful, intentional and communicative practice. Focusing on young children's perspectives of the museum as a place of primary importance enables us to understand the walking and running of young children in the context of their communicative practices in an embodied, emplaced and experienced world.

Keywords

multimodality, literacy, young children, museum, place, walking

Field notes 16 December 2010

We set off as a group trying to keep loosely together to explore the museum. The children ran confidently ahead towards the Arctic gallery. Susie commented to me that it was good to get them out of the house and let them let off steam!

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The toddlers were pleased to see each other, and interacted together as well as with the museum and the grown-ups, excitedly exploring the space.

Moving through the “Arctic World” gallery and then to the natural history gallery, it was difficult to record exactly what happened, as the toddlers moved freely, often bringing their parents along with them, through different exhibits, varying pace from running through the gallery to spending some time exploring an activity such as a jigsaw or a specific interactive exhibit. They moved in and out of contact with each other, sometimes playing together or looking at what others were doing, and sometimes leaving the group and setting off alone across the space. They became more “free range”, splitting up from each other and taking their respective parents with them as they explored the much larger and more complicated space of the natural history gallery.

The above extract is taken from field notes that I wrote following a visit to a museum in northern England with four young children aged 24–26 months (including my own daughter), their mothers and one baby sister. The visit forms part of research to understand what happens when families with children under 36 months old visit a museum, and how they make meaning of and in the space.

Museums generally aim to provide their visitors with a learning experience (Museums Association, 2010; Museums, Libraries and Archives, 2008), and carefully plan the intended learning outcomes of the galleries, hands-on activities, word panels and objects they make available for their visitors (e.g. Macdonald, 2002). Museums also tend to be primarily visual experiences, with some additional opportunities for touching and hearing. Large amounts of written words within the museum aim to provide rich and detailed factual information on the objects they contain (Dudley, 2010). What do such young children make of the museum environment, filled with unfamiliar objects, spaces, words and actions, many of which rely mainly on written language for their meaning? Why do families with such young children visit a museum, and what happens when they are there? As the extract above illustrates, moving through the space, with speed and independence, in groups and alone, leading, following, dragging parents or other children with them along the path, running, stopping and retracing steps, has been a key recurring theme in the observations I have made of young children in the museum.

Bringing together work looking at the multiple modes via which young children communicate and construct meaning (Flewitt, 2005, 2006; Kress, 1997; Lancaster, 2003; Pahl, 2002, 2003; Wohlwend 2009a, 2009b) and methodologies drawing on the sensory and emplaced nature of human

experience (Christensen and O'Brien, 2003; Ingold, 2007, 2008; Pink, 2009), along with considerations of the 'spatial turn' (Soja, 2004: ix) in research more generally, this article explores the meanings that young children and their parents co-constructed in the museum on that day and during a series of visits that followed. In particular, the role and significance of young children's walking and running as a key component of their multimodal communicative practice, which acts as a *place-making* activity in the museum, is considered.

Young children's communication

Vygotsky's original thinking on the sociocultural nature of learning included the proposal that the play activities of young children represent the beginnings of children being able to sever meaning from form. From gestures and play came marks on paper, followed finally by a complex sign system of speech and writing in which form and meaning are completely separate (Vygotsky, 1978: 108):

From this point of view, therefore, children's symbolic play can be understood as a very complex system of "speech" through gestures that communicate and indicate the meaning of playthings. It is only on the basis of these indicatory gestures that playthings themselves gradually acquire their meaning – just as drawing, while initially supported by gesture, becomes an independent sign.

For Vygotsky, the significance of play activities, including actions, gestures, the use of objects and mark making, lay in their potential as stepping stones to written and spoken language. However, more recent work has built on Vygotsky's ideas to argue that gestures, mark makings and the creation and appropriation of objects are all significant aspects of meaning making in their own right, and indeed that both communication and cognition are not as reliant on spoken and written language as Vygotsky proposed (Finnegan, 2002; Kress, 1997). This understanding has developed within a wider context of the unpicking of the concept of the linear nature of children's development as a construct that can be debated (Walkerdine, 1993) and a growing commitment to viewing children as social actors in their own right, rather than merely as future adults (Christensen and James, 2008; James and Prout, 1997).

Kress's (1997) foundational work identified a wide range of young children's communicative modes including, but not restricted to, drawing,

gestures and model making. He argued that these activities are all signs created for others to interpret, and that they are motivated and intentional, reflecting the interests of the sign maker. Kress (1997: 8) placed emphasis on the interpretation of signs across multiple modes, arguing that children draw on a broad range of resources to order to make meaning: 'In learning to read and write, children come as thoroughly experienced makers of meaning, as experienced makers of signs in any medium that is to hand.'

Therefore, within the study of literacy practices from a multimodal perspective, while literacy is still defined as 'language in its written form' (Kress, 1997: 1), the boundaries between forms of language can be seen as 'undergoing rapid unravelling' (Kress, 1997: 2). If all communication takes place across multiple modes, then 'language is partial' (Jewitt and Kress, 2003: 3) and literacy must be understood in the wider context of multimodal communicative practices.

A focus on the multimodal communicative practices of young children, paying close attention to the details of their actions and interactions, illustrates the dominance of non-verbal modes of communication (Flewitt, 2005, 2006; Lancaster, 2003). In addition, texts can be understood as more than written language, as a range of material artefacts imbued with messages and meanings. Kendrick and McKay (2002, 2004) stressed the unrealized potential of drawing as an alternative sign system for young children. Pahl (2002, 2003) and argued that artworks and models of young children can be understood as texts, while Wohlwend (2009a) applied this thinking to commercially produced toys. The multimodal communication of young children involves the use of combinations of modes, often with fast and complex movements between several modes at the same time (Lancaster, 2003; Pahl, 2002; Wohlwend, 2009b). For example, Wohlwend (2009b) described the play inspired by video games between two young boys, which employed drawing, speaking and actions in quick succession in a co-constructed narrative. Within this broad understanding of text making, written language assumes a less dominant position, embedded within the wider context of other communicative practices, such as movement, vocalization and play, which enhance its power and meaning (Rowe, 1998; Wohlwend, 2009a, 2009b).

So what is the purpose of this complex creative dance across multiple modes in 'any medium that is to hand' (Kress, 1997: 8) in which young children engage? First, the multimodal communication of young children seems to be closely related to identity (Kendrick, 2005; Pahl 2002, 2003; Rowsell and Pahl, 2007; Wohlwend, 2009b). Pahl (2002) described the communicative practices of a five-year-old, including frequent drawing and model

making of birds, which she showed were related to both home practices and identity within the family and activities at school. Second, multimodal communication is largely co-constructed between peers and acts as an important way for young children to negotiate social relationships (Flewitt, 2005; Wohlwend, 2009a, 2009b). Wohlwend (2009b) pointed out that the narrative of the video game play described above was adapted at the end with both characters dying simultaneously, a device, she suggested, by one player to 'soften his friend's loss' (Wohlwend, 2009b: 131) and preserve the friendship bond between the two players.

Focusing equally on all modes employed by young children in their communicative practices presents a challenge to the role of spoken and written language, both as the primary means of communication and as the end goal towards which other forms of communication are building. Instead, the emphasis is on understanding the perspectives and viewpoints of the young children who are constructing these complex and creative multimodal practices. These perspectives appear to be situated in the context of their own identity and habitus (Kendrick, 2005; Pahl 2002, 2003; Rowsell and Pahl, 2007; Wohlwend, 2009b), inspired by their sensory perceptions (Wohlwend, 2009b) and frequently co-constructed through their peer relationships (Flewitt, 2005; Wohlwend, 2009a, 2009b).

Children in places

Drawing on what he calls 'the spatial turn', Soja (2004: ix) emphasized the potential for a focus on spatiality to challenge the accepted understandings of society (Leander and Sheehy, 2004; Lefebvre, 1991). Lefebvre (1991) proposed a critical spatial perspective, within which space was a social product and the result of a distribution of power and social ideologies. His proposition for a 'dialectical relationship which exists within the triad of the perceived, the conceived and the lived' (Lefebvre 1991: 39) space placed the focus on the way in which space is produced, by people, within a social context. Leander and Sheehy (2004: 1) state: 'Whereas space was once thought of as empty available and waiting to be filled, recent theorizing about space has brought to light that space is a product and process of socially dynamic relations.'

A challenge for those wishing to give greater attention to space and spatiality is the way in which we imagine space. Is it one thing or several? Lefebvre (1991: 4) argued that there is a hazy understanding within epistemology of what space actually is. Some have suggested a distinction between space (abstract, scientific) and place (imbued with social and cultural meaning)

(Fog Olwin and Gullov, 2003; Moje, 2004). Christensen (2003: 16) argued for the importance of paying attention to children's concrete experience of place and 'the understanding that emerges from embodied movement through place'. Christensen's concept of *emplaced knowledge* (the way in which children attribute meanings and memories to their familiar places), which she argued should not be considered secondary to spatial knowledge (abstract, formal), is a useful way in which to think about the different ways that space and movement within a museum might be conceptualized.

Fog Olwin and Gullov (2003) argued for an emphasis on places constructed by children, rather than those assigned to them by adults, as a way of understanding the perspectives of children and challenging their social marginalization. Similarly, Rasmussen (2004) stressed the distinction between places for children (prescribed by adults) and children's places. If space is socially produced (Leander and Sheehy, 2004; Lefebvre, 1991), then children's meaning making has a role to play in the construction of the places they visit and in which they spend time. In order to examine the way in which this might happen, an emphasis on the embodied lived experience of place for children seems a useful starting point (Christensen, 2003; Hallden, 2003). Therefore, within a conceptualization of space, there is a need to acknowledge both macro effects of politics, ideology and the constructs of society, alongside the everyday sensory experience of individuals, moving through and experiencing a place and imbuing that perception with their own memories and actions (Ingold, 2008; Leander and Sheehy, 2004; Pink, 2009; Rasmussen and Smidt, 2003).

Pink (2009) drew attention to the *embodied* and *emplaced* nature of human experience. She identified *emplaced experience* as a process of the body and mind being in a place. This emphasis on sensory knowing has been embraced by researchers who are concerned with the experiences of children and with how they perceive and make meaning in their world (Christensen and O'Brien, 2003; Fog Olwin and Gullov, 2003). Rasmussen and Smidt (2003) examined the phenomenological experience of being in a place for children, which they argued leads to an understanding of place that goes beyond words. They emphasized the close interrelationship between a familiar place and the child, and the two-way relationship in which 'children are in the neighbourhood, and that the neighbourhood is in the children' (Rasmussen and Smidt, 2003: 88). The neighbourhood is perceived through all the children's senses and becomes part of their being and knowing.

Ingold's (2007, 2008) concept of *entanglement* is useful for further exploring Rasmussen and Smidt's (2003) proposal for the neighbourhood

in children. Ingold argued for a lack of bounded places in favour of a continually shifting mesh of lines of movement. Within this vision, children could be conceptualized as wayfaring through a street, park or, indeed, a museum. In this way, we are able to think about the paths young children follow as they move through a museum space, and the ideologies and physical realities of what they confront as they 'make their way through a world-information' (Ingold, 2008: 1802).

Within this review of the spatial turn, and the potentials for 'putting space first as a critical interpretative perspective' (Soja, 2004: ix), I have considered the hybridity of socially constructed versions of places, which occurs within a cultural and ideological context (Leander and Sheehy, 2004; Lefebvre, 1991; Soja, 2004), alongside the emplaced, embodied (Pink, 2009) and entangled relationship between children and the continually forming environment that they move through (Ingold, 2008). In considering young children in a museum, and their production of time and space in place, there is therefore 'a theoretical concept and practical reality in indissoluble conjunction' (Lefebvre, 1991: 67).

Lines of movement, lines of meaning making

Within studies of walking, the emphasis has been on walking as a process of coming to know, which also impacts on the nature and meaning of a place (de Certeau, 1984; Hall, 2009; Pink, 2009; Pink et al., 2010; Vergunst, 2010). The concept of walking as learning also has methodological implications, with the development of walking methodologies used by researchers in order to understand both place and perception (Pink, 2009; Pink et al., 2010). In addition to being a learning process, it has been argued that walking is essentially *place making* (de Certeau, 1984; Ingold, 2007; Vergunst, 2010), in that different versions of embodied experienced place are produced or reproduced by the path of the walker. Ingold's (2007, 2008) concept of place as a meshwork of paths of movement, both human and non-human, coming together, intertwining and so creating place puts emphasis on the significance of lines of movement, over and above the bounded places illustrated on modern maps and plans. 'Wayfaring, in short, is neither placeless nor place-bound, but place-making' (Ingold, 2007: 101). Therefore, the experiencing and creating of place through walking is not only a physical but a communicative activity.

This connection between lines of movement (which are also about coming to know) and lines of communication (which are about communicating

what one knows), drawn from walking theory (de Certeau, 1984; Ingold, 2007; Vergunst, 2010), also finds parallels in studies of young children's learning and communication. Vygotsky (1978: 107) observed that the significance of young children's drawing lay in gesture, the act of their hand moving through the air:

A child who has to depict running begins by depicting the motion with her fingers, and she regards the resultant marks and dots on the paper as a representation of running. When she goes on to depict jumping, her hand begins to make movements depicting jumps; what appears on the paper remains the same. In general, we are inclined to view children's first drawings and scribbles rather as gestures than as drawings in the true sense of the word.

Athey's (1990) close observations of children in kindergarten linked the lines made when walking, manipulating objects and drawing into dynamic schemas including vertical, back and forth and going around. However, little attention has been given to the walking of young children as both an efficient means of coming to know and a powerful place-making activity.

As young children create lines of movement, they contribute to the ever-forming-and-coming-into-being meshwork that is the place that they inhabit (including a museum during a museum visit). Children in the museum walk to know. As they walk to know they also place make. Where they go and return to takes on meaning and significance. Where they do not go recedes and becomes irrelevant to their experience. Therefore, I propose, young children's walking is a powerful modal choice that can be understood as communicative place making.

In the next section, I will briefly describe the study of children under 36 months old and their families in a museum, before presenting some examples from my emerging research on how young children are using walking in their communicative place making.

The study

The museum where the above action took place is located in northern England and contains social history, natural history, archaeology and art collections. The museum has won awards for being particularly 'family friendly'. Five permanent and one temporary gallery are located off a broad central corridor, with automatic doors, bright lights and moving video screens on the walls. Special efforts have been made to cater for the needs of families with young

children, with a buggy park, changing facilities and a family-friendly cafe near the entrance. Each gallery contains: a lot of space for free movement; exhibits both in cases and out of cases available to touch; word panels and video screens; and hands-on activities ranging from tunnels to computers, push buttons that play music to coloured magnets to be moved around a board.

The study adopted an ethnographic approach, focusing on the experiences of eight families visiting their local museum over the course of a year. The methodological choice was based on the perspective that what happens when a family visits a museum is grounded in, references and is inseparable from the rest of their everyday life. I felt that an ethnographic approach would allow an understanding of the museum based on the perspectives of the families and children as primary, rather than from the vision of the museum service. In addition, ethnography may be particularly effective in recognizing alternative perspectives in general (Heath and Street, 2008; Jeffrey and Troman, 2004), and in hearing the voices of young children in particular (Christensen, 2004; Davis et al., 2008), because of the attention paid to what people do as well as what they say.

A large time commitment was requested of the families taking part in the research: monthly visits to the museum over the course of a year (between December 2010 and November 2011), plus extra time for parents in the evenings with me, reflecting on video and field notes from previous museum visits and taking part in informal interviews. Therefore, participants for the research were recruited through word of mouth, involving a group of friends that I had known since my daughter was a baby and who had a keen interest in being involved in my work and learning more about the learning and communication of their own children. The families all knew each other well before the research (including myself and my daughter), but not all of them had been to the museum before.

Participants in museum visits

- Clare and Bryan (son, aged 24 months in December 2010)
- Tina and Millie (daughter, aged 26 months in December 2010). Tina also brought her baby daughter Sienna, four months old in December 2010.
- Susie and Liam (son, aged 25 months in December 2010). Susie also had a new baby daughter in January 2011.
- Me and Izzy (daughter, aged 24 months in December 2010) and Izzy's father Owen.
- All names (except mine) are pseudonyms.

During the monthly museum visits, I took part as a participant observer, with my own daughter, Izzy. My identity during the visits was a specific combination of mother, researcher and friend to the other participants. This will undoubtedly have affected both how children and parent participants behaved during the visits and my own perceptions and recordings of what these visits were like. I thought carefully about the ethical implications of involving my own family in the research and the positional implications of presenting myself in an ambiguous role of both participant-mother and researcher. The strength of my approach has been the way in which I have been able to both build up a strong rapport with participants during the research and empathize with them, sharing a sensory and emotional perspective of the museum visit to as close an extent as would perhaps ever be possible (considering I was the one who instigated the research and hold ultimate control over it). When the children ran around, acted in a 'disruptive' manner, disappeared from view, got tired and grumpy, or reacted to something in a surprising and captivating way, I was very much caught up in the feelings and responses these experiences provoked.

The data collected consisted of field notes and video footage made using a small handheld Flip camera. The video footage was recorded by both myself and the other mothers, with an open brief, depending on what they wanted to film and what they felt was significant. The only limitation was that we could not film other visitors, as they had not consented to be involved in the research. Video footage was also taken in a more structured way, filming a specific child for 10 minutes continuously during each visit. In analysing the data, attention was given to modal choice, sensory experience of the museum and movement. Multimodal transcription was an important part of making sense of the data, looking in detail at 'micro moments of multimodal meaning making' (Flewitt, 2011: 297) within an ethnographic context. In addition, walking maps of the museum were created using the video footage, which are discussed in more detail below.

Dataset

The data used for this paper were collected during and following two museum visits with the families in December 2010 and three museum visits in June/July 2011:

1. Five sets of field notes written by me (one after each visit). Each set of field notes was between 4,000 and 7,000 words long.

2. Flip video footage from the museum: 26 videos in December, 36 videos in June/July. Video recordings ranged from four seconds to nine minutes 52 seconds long.
3. Three walking maps of the museums drawn by me using video footage from the museum visits in December (one each for Liam, Millie and Bryan).

An ethical approach, which accommodated the needs of very young children, was planned, in which adult participants gave their verbal and written consent to being involved in the research at the start of the project and at key points during the research. Consent of the children to participate was obtained on a moment-by-moment basis, based on the verbal and non-verbal cues the children gave, as interpreted by myself and their parents. Museum visits frequently ended in the cafe or with a run around the park, at a point when the children indicated that they were hungry, tired or needed a change of scene. Adult participants chose pseudonyms for themselves and their children. The museum service also gave consent for the research to take place in their museum, and for videoing.

During each visit the families allowed the children to lead the way down the corridors and into the galleries that appealed to them. Moving around the space was a negotiation between the parents, who wanted to keep vaguely together as a group, and the routes each child wanted to take. Within reason, the children were however free to walk and run where they chose, confronting objects and spaces along the way and responding to what they experienced both individually and as a group.

Examples of young children's movement in the museum

In this next section, I present three examples of young children's walking/running from my dataset, in order to further elaborate on the process through which young children *place make* through walking as a method of both learning and communication.

Example 1: Obliteration

As the significance of walking, running and dancing began to emerge repeatedly in my field notes from visits to the museum, I began to think about the way in which movement was being used by the young children to produce their own versions of the museum. Using continuous 10-minute bouts of filming of one child enabled me to transpose their movements onto paper to create a walking map (see Figure 1 for an example). Watching the video

For me, these walking maps act as a heuristic for thinking about young children's movement and place making in the museum. Transcribing the walking maps into a drawn mode acknowledges the agency young children have to construct their own experiences in the museum. Following Christensen's (2003) plea not to value spatial knowledge over embodied knowledge, I avoided drawing the walking maps over an official ground plan of the museum exhibitions. By focusing solely on the emplaced experience of young children in the museum, the walking maps show how the walking of young children produces a new version of the museum each time, one that includes some parts of the gallery and completely obliterates others. Drawing on Ingold's (2008) argument for wayfaring as place making, the places shown on the walking map are not an example of where young children did and did not go in the exhibition, but represent the sum total of the exhibition for that one child (admittedly in this example just for the 10-minute period that the walking map refers to). From the perspective of the child, there is nothing else except the places that the child moved to, and the experiences and meaning making that took place at those locations. This is represented in the walking map in Figure 1 by the focus on the line of movement (now a drawn line), rather than on the bounded spaces traditionally shown on a museum floor plan (following Ingold, 2008).

Example two: Indicating interest

Vignette of Millie and her mum Tina at a plasma screen exhibit in the natural history gallery at the museum

Walking together through the natural history gallery, Mille walks in front, her mother Tina following with baby Sienna in a front facing carrier. I am following the group with a video camera. Mille peers round the corner into a darker enclosed part of the gallery called "The power of nature". She runs in through the small door which looks like a fissure in rock, followed by Tina. The plasma screen on her left immediately catches Millie's eye: she runs over to it and reaches up high to place her hand on the screen. Tina approaches and says: "Do you want me to lift you up?", at the same time bending down to pick her up. The lightning effect on the screen changes, centring around Millie's right hand, which she holds flat against the screen. Millie looks around at both me, Tina and the video camera and says "zigging and zooming", while continuing to keep her hand on the screen.

Tina places Millie on the floor now (I think she was getting heavy!), saying "zigging and zooming is it?". Millie runs over to the opposite side of this small

enclosed space, where a floor to ceiling case displays models, skeletons and stuffed animals, all mixed together. My daughter Izzy enters the space. Millie sees Izzy and shouts, “zigging and zooming all over the place”, while running back towards the plasma screen exhibit. She demonstrates to Izzy by reaching up again to touch the screen. Meanwhile, Izzy has walked over to stand by the display case of animal objects, and Millie runs over to her, saying “I——, it’s an ant” and pointing into the case. The two girls stand side by side looking into the case. After a few minutes, Izzy wanders off. Millie returns for the third time to the plasma screen, and reaches up high to touch it again.

In this vignette, Millie makes several return journeys to a specific part of the exhibition that seems to have caught her imagination: a plasma screen. Her modal choices during this episode also include gesture (reaching up with her hand), gaze (which she uses to catch our attention) and spoken language (including her own label that she gives to what she is experiencing: ‘zigging and zooming’). However, the choice to walk continually back to the plasma screen from other parts of the gallery feels significant. She could have chosen to stay by the plasma screen until she had finished looking at it, then move on. The shape Millie created through walking during her return trips to the plasma screen can be seen in the top left-hand corner of Figure 1.

Particularly striking in this example is the way in which the same communicative sign can be seen dancing across multiple modes. The zigzag effect of the lightning on the plasma screen was creatively captured in words when Millie named it ‘zigging and zooming’, and then physically realized by Millie’s movement as she walked in a zigzag shape between the plasma screen and other areas of the exhibition. By walking in a zigzag, Millie not only included the plasma screen in her journey around the museum, but included it several times. By immediately returning to the plasma screen when she saw Izzy, she demonstrated through walking what, in her opinion, was special and deserved Izzy’s attention in this part of the museum. This activity could be compared to drawing a line underneath important aspects of a written text that one wants to remember and share with others.

Example three: Linking and co-producing

Field notes 20 June 2011

The three children enter the mock kitchen area and begin to carry out a game which links the two role play areas – the kitchen and the shop. They run in a

straight line, all following each other between the two areas many times, linking them together with their movement. They bring money and sausages from the butcher's shop into the kitchen. They stand in the butcher's shop and role play "kitchens", for example Liam tells his mum: "After we have soup we have some other things we have some blackberries and then we have rice pudding." The three children run back to the kitchen area and then the shop many times. I notice that one of the children has shoved some sausages from the shop into the oven in the kitchen.

In this extract from field notes written following a museum visit six months after the initial visit described in my introduction, Liam returns with his mother Susie, new baby sister (now five months), Liam's grandmother and cousin (aged three years), myself and Izzy. This time we went into the 'Life and Times' exhibition, which focuses on everyday life in the local area in the past (particularly the last 200 years). The exhibition is in a very large space separated into different small areas using partitions and cases. In one part of the gallery the focus is on homes, with a display of old toys, a role-play kitchen area and domestic objects in cases. In another part of the gallery the focus is on work, with a mock butcher's shop set up in front of a screen showing videoed memories of butcher's-shop owners from the local area.

On this occasion, all three children worked together and walked many times between the two separate role-play areas of the kitchen and the butcher's shop. The way in which the three children walked along the same path in succession, repeatedly, added power to the communicative action by drawing the attention of others to what they were doing. Understanding this effort as intentional (Kress, 1997), and worthy of our attention, we can begin to wonder why the children decided to make this link through movement during this visit. We can acknowledge the existence and significance for the children of this link or path. One explanation could be that the children were classifying elements of the exhibition according to what you do there (role play) rather than thematically (home, work). However, this is only one of several options. The children used a variety of modes to link the two areas together, including the carrying of the sausages from the butcher's to the kitchen area, and the performance of a kitchen scene in the butcher's shop (which included both spoken words and gesture). However, the walking between the two areas, repeatedly, using direct lines of movement, following one after the other, can be seen as a key way in which this multimodal meaning making was performed. Drawing on Christensen's (2003)

distinction between spatial and emplaced knowledge, it could be argued that while the abstract floor plan of the museum gallery would show the kitchen and the butcher's shop as belonging to different parts of the exhibition, the emplaced knowledge of the exhibition co-produced by these three children on this day meshes these specific sites together as two connected parts of the same place.

Discussion

In presenting some of my emerging thinking from my experiences with young children in a museum, I have made a commitment to both the significance of walking and running through space in terms of young children's perspectives of the museum and the key role these actions play in their multi-modal communicative practices. Just as play activities have been recognized as a complex and meaningful combination of multiple modes, drawing on creativity, identity and peer and family relationships to construct communicative signs (Kendrick, 2005; Wohlwend, 2009a), walking and running must not be dismissed as the 'noise' that happens in between focused engagement and learning in a museum (or any other environment), but as a central aspect.

Walking and running through a place are closely related to one's embodied emplaced experience of that place (Christensen, 2003; Pink, 2009; Pink et al., 2010). In paying attention to young children's emplaced experience, I seek to understand and emphasize children's places, rather than places for children (Rasmussen, 2004; Rasmussen and Smidt, 2003). This museum is undoubtedly constructed by the adults who manage and run it as a place for children, in that the museum service considers families to be a key audience. However, I am interested in children's own interpretation of that place, which is a reaction to what they find or perceive in the museum environment but constructs an independent and individual way of knowing based on the children's own perspectives, interests and meaning making. I argue that an understanding of a museum as a children's place is essential to provide a realistic context for the meaning making of young children in that place. The examples from my research have emphasized the nature of young children's understanding of place that goes beyond words (Rasmussen and Smidt, 2003) and are a complex mixture of sensory emplaced experience and the memories and meaning that young children bring to that place (Christensen, 2003).

By taking seriously where and how young children move as an intentional act, indicating the interests of the sign maker (Kress, 1997), I have proposed that walking is communicative and can be understood as a modal choice.

This proposal builds on our understanding of the range of modes employed by young children and the fast and complex way in which communicative ideas move between modes (Flewitt, 2008; Kress, 1997; Lancaster, 2003; Pahl, 2002; Wohlwend 2009a, 2009b). I have argued that the literature suggests that young children's multimodal meaning making is connected to identity construction (Kendrick, 2005; Pahl 2002, 2003; Rowsell and Pahl, 2007; Wohlwend, 2009b) and the negotiation of social relationships (Flewitt, 2005; Wohlwend, 2009a, 2009b), and both these aspects can be observed in the walking and running of young children in the examples I have presented. In example two, 'Indicating interest', Millie moves in response to her discovery of and interest in the plasma screen. She physically returns to the screen three times, and also uses gesture, gaze and words to draw others' (myself and her mother's) attention to her connection with the screen. Through gesture and movement, Millie constructs herself as someone who is impressed by and interested in the plasma screen. The plasma screen also becomes a medium for negotiating social interaction, particularly when Izzy enters the space. Millie immediately responds to Izzy's arrival, and the way in which she responds is centred on the plasma screen. Using words ('zigging and zooming all over the place') and movement (running quickly and purposefully back towards the plasma screen), Millie invites Izzy to engage with her through the medium of the plasma screen.

The work undertaken by young children when they walk and run, and when they make decisions about how and where to move, is understood in this discussion as communicative place making. Drawing on Ingold's (2007, 2008) concept of a 'world-in-formation' (Ingold, 2008: 1802) made up of a continually shifting mesh of lines of movement, the museum itself can be understood not as a bounded entity, with four walls and a fixed layout of cases and objects, but as a mesh of lines of movement coming together. There are the lines of movement created by each exhibit, moving from the local area and across the globe to be in the museum place. There are the lines of movement created by the curators and museum staff as they work to make these exhibits available to the public, and to create a learning experience. There are the lines of movement created by each visitor who passes through the museum. Each visitor's line of movement enters the museum place, meshing with all the other lines that are coming together in that place, and weaves its own path. This is the context in which we can understand the walking and running of a very young child in the museum. Example one, 'Obliteration', seeks to emphasize the importance of lines of movement over the background through which they move by transcribing those lines onto a blank piece

of paper. In this way, the 'walking map' acts as a heuristic to enable us to think about a museum that is constantly remade, even by the youngest children, on a moment-by moment-basis, and which we are only able to recognize by refusing to privilege spatial knowledge over emplaced knowledge (Christensen, 2003).

According to Ingold's (2008) concept of entanglement, these walking and running lines are not separate from the place through which they move, but change that place, so that the world is constantly in flux. In addition, entanglement with the museum changes the children as they move through and learn about that place. Following Rasmussen and Smidt (2003), I argue that these new understandings go beyond words and are instead manifested in new and growing understandings of the whole body as a resource for both discovery and communication. In example two, Millie brings together a wide range of modes around her fascination with the zigzag on the plasma screen, as she touches, sees, speaks and walks her new understanding of 'zigging and zooming all over the place'. In example three, 'Linking and co-producing', three young children enact an imaginative game through talk, gesture and the use of external objects, which also draws on powerful, deliberate and coordinated effort to physically walk a line between two locations in the museum. Therefore, place is constructed not only both physically and experientially, but also conceptually (Leander and Sheehy, 2004; Lefebvre, 1991), and physicality, experience and concept are all related to and expressed in the multimodal communicative practices of the young children.

Additionally, I have argued that these new ways of moving through space and communicating through movement are closely and directly entangled in the mesh of multimodal communicative practices that surrounds and supports early emerging childhood literacy. By paying attention to the actions of young children in an unfamiliar and exciting location such as a museum, we can perhaps begin to understand the way in which moment-by-moment micro-level meaning making takes place across a wide range of modes. A key concern for those studying multimodal literacy practices is the way in which 'language is partial' (Jewitt and Kress, 2003: 3) and modes work together to produce meaning. Literacy can therefore be understood as part of a whole, a mode embedded within other modes to make up a communicative sign, which is always multimodal. A second concern for those interested in early childhood literacy is the way in which the use of modes for sign making by young children emerges within a sociocultural context, and the position of the beginnings of both spoken and written language within that context. Flewitt (2008: 122, original emphasis) argues that 'children become literate

in many ways, not just through language, but through learning to use combinations of different *modes*, such as gesture, gaze, movement, image, layout, music and sound effects'. I argue, in my research, that the museum space, which is large, unstructured and often perceived as fairly 'safe' by parents, enables us to see particularly rich examples of children's use of walking and running in the context of their communicative practices.

Flewitt (2008: 134) describes a case study of Zara who uses gesture, whole-body movement and words to describe the experience of playing with a bubble machine. In this example, Flewitt argues for the affordances of gesture, body movement and words in Zara's work to convey what the bubble machine (which is not there at the time) is like. She also points out the choices that need to be made in the implementation of communication through the mode of movement, such as the use of space. This case study makes a useful parallel for the examples I have presented of young children's walking and running in a museum. The modal choice of running and walking in the museum has communicative properties that spoken language and even gesture would not afford; it is extremely effective in drawing others' attention to areas of the museum, linking self with specific aspects of the space and also impacting on that space – that is, *place making*, as discussed above. In using walking and running as a modal choice, young children are making specific and intentional choices about where they go and how they go, in terms of physicality (running, jumping, dancing), in terms of the way they combine walking with other modes (e.g. gesture and words such as 'zigging and zooming' in example two) and in terms of how they involve or work with other children to implement this communicative practice (as in example three).

Conclusion

This paper argues for the need for greater attention to be paid to the walking and running of young children as a key element of their multimodal communicative practices. First, I have emphasized the concept of space as a social construct, and children's places as being spaces imbued with meaning and significance specific to the emplaced and sensory experiences of the individual child (Christensen, 2003; Ingold, 2007, 2008; Rasmussen and Smidt, 2003). An understanding of place as a dynamic, shifting and subjectively perceived entity is vital for acknowledging the agency and perspectives of young children as a starting point for our consideration of their multimodal communicative practices. Second, I have offered some examples of ways in which

children in the museum moved through space, both as a way of coming to know the space and also as an intentional communicative practice. I have argued that these place-making practices impact on both the 'world-in-formation' (Ingold, 2008: 1802) and on the child's embodied growing understanding of the nature of both the world and communicative practices. Therefore, the boundaries between moving through space and communicating through movement are blurred; communicative sign making emerges as a result of the entanglement between child and the perceived and conceived (Lefebvre, 1991) experiences of the space through which they move.

Third, following others who have studied the multimodal nature of literacy practices (Jewitt and Kress, 2003; Kress, 1997; Pahl, 2003; Wohlwend, 2009a, 2009b), I have proposed that the emerging literacy and language of young children cannot be studied in isolation from other communicative modes, and therefore greater thinking about the relationships between lines of walking, gesture, speech and writing is needed in order to enhance our understanding of the ways in which young children acquire practices and attribute meaning within the context of early communicative practices and emerging literacy. By taking seriously where and how young children go, we can recognize the full range of modes via which young children can express their ideas and responses, and thus acknowledge the agency of young children to both construct meaning and communicate about their developing experiences of the world.

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